twenty-eight states, which accounted for 85 per cent of all BJP seats in 2014 and 58.4 per cent in 2019.

Invert the map and the political landscape looks very different for the BJP. Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Kerala and the Union Territory of Puducherry account for 130 seats in southern India: over one-fifth of the Lok Sabha's 543 seats. In 2014, in sharp contrast to the north, the BJP won only 16.1 per cent (twenty-one) of these seats; they accounted for only 7.4 per cent of its total tally. In 2019, it won only 22.3 per cent (twenty-nine), accounting for just 9.57 per cent of its final tally.

Karnataka is the region's outlier—the big question is why.

The party's model of political mobilisation, based on north India-focused identity politics, remained largely ineffective in the rest of south India. So, what was the BJP's secret sauce in Karnataka? How has it consistently won a majority of parliamentary seats in four successive general elections between 2004 and 2019 in this state? Of Karnataka's twenty-eight Lok Sabha seats, the BJP won eighteen in 2004, nineteen in 2009, seventeen in 2014 and twenty-five in 2019. It remains the only southern state where a saffron government has ever come to power.[2] As with people or companies, the failures of political parties tell us as much about them as their successes—and the south was definitely a bridge too far for the BJP until 2021. Except for Karnataka, where it managed to become the pre-eminent party despite being likened to 'north Indian imperial invaders' from the ancient past by local regional parties. Is there a Karnataka model of BJP politics? How does it work and why does it not work in the other southern states? Are the BJP's Karnataka gains replicable? Will this one state become the base from which the party will grow out into the rest of south India?

The Tumkur Factor: The View from Siddaganga Math

The shaded grand courtyard of the Sree Siddaganga Math (monastery), one of the oldest and most influential shrines of the Shiva-focused Lingayat sect, is an unlikely place for a political conversation. It is nestled amid rocky hillocks—the Ramalinga, Siddaganga and Shivagange Hills—that house several sacred